# The Explorers Club

## By Nell Benjamin

**LUCIUS:** **(Pg 5-6)** Gentlemen, good evening and welcome to the annual meeting of the Explorers Club. Now, excellent news for our club: Two of our own have an audience with Queen Victoria. Professor Cope, as many of you know, discovered a deadly new species of cobra . . .

**COPE:** *(He stands, crooning to the cobra draped around his neck)* **(Pg 30)** Snakes are wonderful animals! They are misunderstood. They are fascinating and charming, and I like snakes! *(Beat)* **(Pg 6)** Her name is Rosie.

**LUCIUS:** Yes. Thank you, Professor Cope. Also presenting at the palace tomorrow is our own Professor Walling, who has done some amazing behavioral studies with guinea pigs.

**WALLING:** *(He stands, holding a guinea pig)* ***Cavia porcellus,*** if you please. Very clever. I designed an experiment in which I put food outside their cages to see if they would be able to figure out the latches. And they did. Now I can't find any of them. This one, Jane, had some trouble with the latch, so I've still got her. *(glumly)* In retrospect it wasn't the best-designed experiment.

**COPE:** *(Helpfully)* But you've proven their intelligence!

**WALLING:** *(Cheering up)* Yes. Yes I have!

**ALL:** To Science!

## INTRODUCTION

***ACTOR:*** *The Explorers Club*
***ACTRESS:*** *A scientific farce of Biblical and British proportions by Nell Benjamin*

**LUCIUS:** **(Pg 6-7)** And now, gentlemen, I am very excited to introduce an exceptional explorer and scientist, whom, in fact, I hope to propose for membership. She has recently achieved

**WALLING:** *(interrupting)* There are no female members of this club!

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**LUCIUS:** Gentlemen, please. We are men of progress. Please welcome Miss Phyllida Spotte-Hume, the first explorer to discover the Lost City of Pahatlabong! *(he leads the applause)*

**PHYLLIDA:** Gentlemen of the Explorers Club. May I present to you: a genuine warrior of the NaKong tribe of the Lost City of Pahatlabong! Luigi, ***na'I haa'ru.*** *(Luigi steps forward. He is painted blue, wearing a combination of tattoos, feathers and knickerbockers.)*

**LUIGI:** Luigi.

**PHYLLIDA:** His name is not actually Luigi, but ***Loo-ah-JA-mweno-wepta***. I have shortened it to "Luigi" for simplicity's sake.

**LUIGI:** **(Pg 15)** *(With great solemnity and hand gestures. Phyllida translates)*

| | |
|---|---|
| ***NaKongi weilah gweisha.*** | *(In my country there is a saying.)* |
| ***Do haaru seefkai basei.*** | *(On the ground there are many snakes.)* |
| ***Kwei haa'ru eekweet shasa basei.*** | *(And over your head are many rabid monkeys.)* |
| ***Mem haa'ru pog fhwt! Fhw! Fhwt!*** | *(But throw enough rocks around in all directions,)* |
| ***weil basei hatlala.*** | *(. . . and you will have temporary peace.)* |

**PHYLLIDA:** **(Pg 7)** My journey to Pahatlabong was grueling. Deserted by guides, I crawled delirious through the swamps, and when found by Luigi, I was in possession of nothing more than the clothes on my back and a spoon. . . *(She holds up a spoon.)*

**LUIGI:** *(Luigi bows down) Mogweet Aleili!*

**PHYLLIDA:** Luckily for me, the NaKong god, Mogweet, is spoon-shaped, so they greeted me as a messenger from their god. **(Pg 8)** I will end this lecture here, as tomorrow I will be presenting Luigi to the queen.

**LUIGI:** **(Pg 9)** *(Bows)* Mah-jah-stay! *(they exit the podium)*

**WALLING:** **(Pg 8)** Wonderful lecture, Miss Spotte-Hume. I never thought I'd see a woman present at the Explorers Club, but you have proved me wrong.

**SLOANE:** *(introducing himself to Phyllida)* Sloane. Robert Sloane. Professor of archeo-theology. Biblical science. God created science, and God wrote the Bible, and the Bible exhorts us to beware the evil woman. **(Pg 19)** *(To Luigi; smiling but shouting as to a dog)* Luigi! Have you read the BIBLE?! The BIBLE?!

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**LUIGI:** BYE-BULL

**LUCIUS:** Sloan, he's just repeating words he doesn't understand.

**SLOANE:** That's good enough for the Church.

**LUCIUS:** **(Pg 9)** *(Offering his hand)* Hello there, Luigi . . .

**PHYLLIDA:** No, Lucius! *(Luigi slaps him hard across the face.)* That is how the NaKong introduce themselves.

**LUCIUS:** Meeting the queen is a terrible idea.

**PHYLLIDA:** Don't be silly, Lucius. You don't shake hands with the queen. *(She exits with Luigi)*

**PERCY:** **(Pg 15-16)** So what are you up to, Sloane?

**SLOANE:** I'm presenting to the Irish Society tomorrow. A breakthrough in Biblical studies. You know the Ten Lost Tribes of Israel? Reuben, Simeon . . . Zebulon, Levi, Judah, and Dan? The Bible says they were captured by the Assyrians. Sold into slavery. And they're never mentioned again. Not once in the whole Bible. No one knew where they went.

**PERCY:** And you think you've figured out where they went?

**SLOANE:** I have. They went to ***Ireland!*** Think about it. How many Irishmen do you know named "Dan"? A lot. I believe the Ten Lost Tribes of the Hebrews brought the Ark of the Covenant to Ireland. I'm going to dig for it!

**LUCIUS:** Just to be clear: You're going to tell the Irish Society that they are actually Jewish?

**SLOANE:** They need to know.

**ALL:** To Science!

******* The following day after the Queen's presentation *******

**PHYLLIDA:** **(Pg 21-23)** *(Phyllida enters, in a panic.)* Oh, what a state I'm in! I don't know ***what*** to do! Disaster at the palace. Luigi bowed beautifully. But then the queen put out her hand to help him rise! He struck her across the face! It was chaos. I had to create a diversion. So I . . . I opened Rosie's cage.

**LUCIUS:** You released a deadly cobra in the throne room?

**PHYLLIDA:** They were much more concerned with a poisonous snake than with poor Luigi, so we were able to escape.

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**COPE:** *(Cope enters, with Rosie draped over him.)* Oh, what a state I'm in! I don't know ***what*** to do! Is Walling back yet?

**LUCIUS:** We thought he was at the palace with you?

**COPE:** He was! But then Rosie got out of her cage. It was chaos. I thought they were going to *kill* Rosie, but ... Rosie never went near Her Majesty. She was distracted. By Jane. Jane finally figured out how to open the latch on the cage. Rosie ate Jane, Lucius! Right there in the throne room. Walling ... I've never seen him *look* like that. I grabbed Rosie and ran for it. Why, why did Jane have to figure out the latch right then? Stupid animal! *(Walling enters, enraged.)*

**WALLING:** "STUPID ANIMAL"?! *"STUPID ANIMAL"?!* Do you see this? *(Walling produces Jane's tiny collar with the bell. He shakes it repeatedly at Cope. Ring.)* ***This*** is what's left of her! *(Walling collapses in tears and exits – Humphries enters)*

**HUMPHRIES:** **(Pg 24-26)** Gentlemen, I am Sir Humphries, private secretary to the queen. Direct me to Miss Phyllida Spotte-Hume. I've come to speak with her about the incident at the palace. *(COPE points to Phyllida)* No one is here to punish you, Miss Spotte-Hume. In fact, Her Majesty is rather in need of your help.

**PHYLLIDA:** Anything. Anything, of course.

**HUMPHRIES:** Excellent. Would you be so kind as to provide some kind of map to the Lost City of Pahatlabong? We've declared war on them, so we need to know where they are.

**PHYLLIDA:** What?!

**HUMPHRIES:** We like to be as precise as we can with this sort of thing. We don't want to get the army out there attacking Malaysia by mistake. You can't imagine the paperwork when that happens.

**PHYLLIDA:** You said no one was going to be punished!

**HUMPHRIES:** I said ***you*** weren't going to be. You're British. That NaKong chappie is ***not***.

**PHYLLIDA:** But he didn't mean any harm!

**HUMPHRIES:** Madam, he slapped the Queen of England. In the face.

**PHYLLIDA:** That's the way they say hello!

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**HUMPHRIES:** And now *we* get to say hello. With artillery. That wild man came as a representative of his people and his people slapped the queen. Let me make myself clear. If you look out that window, you will see this club surrounded by Her Majesty's guards. We have come for the savage and the map. You're not in a position to refuse. *(Phyllida responds in dismay then has an idea)*

**SLOANE:** *(rushes in, breathless and afraid.)* Disaster! I barely escaped with my life. I was attacked by the Irish Society; they didn't appreciate being called Jewish.

**PERCY:** They're worked up because you called them Jewish?

**SLOANE:** I also said they should be relocated to Palestine. *(Everyone groans.)*

**ALL:** **(Pg 16)** To Science!

******** The next day ********

**PERCY:** **(Pg 28-29)** Lucius, the time has come. We deliver Luigi and the map or prepare for battle, and frankly I don't like our chances. Shall I wake Phyllida?

**LUCIUS:** Phyllida's gone. She slipped through the lines last night. [but] she left a note. *(he brandishes the note)* She's going back to Pahatlabong to warn them!

******** Days pass, but the problem remains ********

**HUMPHRIES:** **(Pg 33)** *(Enters)* Gentlemen. I have returned.

**LUCIUS:** **(Pg 34)** *(All business)* Sir Humphries, we're eager to find a diplomatic solution.

**PERCY:** Thing is, Humphries, Phyllida's scarpered to Pahatlabong.

**HUMPHRIES:** And her savage?

**LUCIUS:** She took him with her. **(Pg 44-45)** Sir, don't you think the Crown could forgive the NaKong?

**HUMPHRIES:** What? No . . . if we went around indiscriminately forgiving everybody, what would that make us?

**SLOANE:** Christian?

**HUMPHRIES:** For your country and your club, will you find Phyllida Spotte-Hume!

**PHYLLIDA:** *(Phyllida enters, looking ragged but determined)* Sir Humphries. Here is your map. It will take you straight to Pahatlabong. But when you get there, you will find nothing. I

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warned the NaKong to flee, that the British were coming with fire and steel. They wanted to fight. But I held up my spoon and commanded them to disperse; to go where even I could never find them. That map will bring you to where they used to be, but the city is leveled and the people are gone.

**HUMPHRIES:** *(Threateningly)* My course is clear, Miss Phyllida Spotte-Hume.

**LUCIUS:** You should give her a medal.

**HUMPHRIES:** *(Annoyed)* What? Why?

**LUCIUS:** Think. The queen wanted Pahatlabong leveled and its people gone. Phyllida's done that for you without the expense and trouble of trucking the British army through the jungle. Your mission is a complete success.

**HUMPHRIES:** *(changing his tune)* Madam, it appears you have done your country a service. **(Pg 46)** I must say this is ***most*** satisfactory. I shall withdraw the guards and report my happy news to the queen. **(Pg 47)** I speak for Her Majesty when I say I am impressed, very impressed by the Explorers Club. *(Humphries exits. Walling and Cope rush to the window.)*

**COPE:** He's moving out the army! We're saved!

**WALLING:** And our club is more prestigious than ever!

**ALL:** To Science!

## SOURCE INFORMATION

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